

THE SPECIAL LINE of bespoke handmade shoes by the sultan of couture, J.J. Valaya, walk his walk. Evolved from the bloodline of the ornate *mojris* and *juttis* that accessorised the Indian groom in the Nineties and at the turn of the century, and their embroidered, velvet-fused leather lovechild, the pump moccasin with mughal cut silhouettes in the last decade—this range of meticulously crafted, hand embroidered and hand stained leather shoes of the **Alma Collection** launched last year, leave a footprint of understated opulence—much like Vallaya's recent oeuvre. The formal oxford shapes are disrupted by a risqué side placement of the laces and the more sculpted than ornate upper is welted onto the signature leather soles of the shoes that cost ₹69,000 for a pair. The hitherto singular motifs embroidered on the vamps of the shoes have opened up into multiple aureate patterns—made with rich yet minimal patches of rich silk thread work or gold *zari* embroidery. What steps out is as much a shoe for a grand reception as it is for the nightclub. Both *bandhgala* suit and jeans friendly, yet married to none, it makes an edgy personal style statement. Sure to lower all eyes.